



a reboot of *Resident Evil*. The survival horror title had sort of worn out its welcome and really needed a shot in the arm. Mikami took over directorial duties and experiments with a wide range of gameplay styles. He even tried a more modern version of the pre-rendered background but scrapped it when he realised that it was causing more issues than it was actually solving. He then went with an over-the-top shoulder camera but kept the tank controls we were all familiar with. Mikami also changed the setting of the game, moving from castles and laboratories to a creepy, hostile Eastern European village. Gone was the imperfect aiming from the previous RE games. In its place was a tight, focused aiming system that prioritised precision and timing.

The game went on to become a massive hit and Mikami was once again lauded as a game-changer when it came to the third-person perspective. Games like *Gears of War*, *Dead Space* and many more adopted the over-the-top shoulder perspective. To say that it was revolutionary is to sell it short.

After all the success in Capcom, Mikami felt like he needed to spread his wings and was moved to a new development studio within Capcom called Clover Studios. Here he experi-

mented with a lot of gameplay styles and directed one of my personal favourite games – *Godhand*. Unlike his previous efforts, *Godhand* was an insane, over-the-top action game with an emphasis on combining different melee attacks to create the world's coolest combos. While *Godhand* did not reach the heights that RE4 did (game journos hated the game when it was released), it showed us that Mikami was capable of more than just horror. He understood action as well and *Godhand* was the perfect vehicle to show off those new skills.

Vanquishing Competition

After years in Capcom, Mikami decided that a fresh start was needed and formed Seeds Inc, another game studio under the Platinum Games umbrella. It was clear that Mikami was looking at moving away from horror and into a more action-oriented style. Enter: *Vanquish*. The game was a fast-paced sci-fi romp that saw you zip across the battlefield in these rocket-powered skates and blow up robots and enemies up with the panache of a Mad Max film. *Vanquish* was fast, unforgiving and unapologetically campy. Fed up with cover-based shooters, Mikami made it a point to punish players for being too conservative by hiding behind cover. The aim

of the game was to hit the pedal to the metal without looking back once! And while it did not break sales records, the game was lauded by critics and fans alike as a no-nonsense video game where the only aim is to have fun. That was the one thing that Mikami never forgot. He always understood that even when audiences are scared stiff, they should still have fun while playing his games.

His final year at Platinum games was not a great one and Mikami and his team were relegated to working on *Bayonetta* as a support studio. Not feeling like he was achieving what he set out to, Mikami left Clover and Platinum to form his own gaming company called Tango Gameworks.

Evil And Tango

After finally being given free rein on development, Mikami began work on a spiritual successor to RE4 in *The Evil Within*. And while the game did not set the world on fire, it still showed us that Mikami had what it takes to craft a truly unique and terrifying experience. *The Evil Within* followed the same gameplay style as RE4 but with tighter controls and a weird, horror/sci-fi story. Released in 2014, *The Evil Within* went on to sell rather well and even got a sequel. While the second game did not live up to the same hype and scare factor as the original, it was still a tight, focused experience.

He then went on to direct *Ghostwire: Tokyo* which was not the seller it was touted to be. The game was a bit bland and followed the western design principles that modern gamers hate – blaring objective markers, linear paths etc. RE4, this was not. But after such an impressive resume of previous titles, it is only fair to give Mikami a pass, this once.

Who knows what he's currently working on? The man has always been rather secretive about his work; but one thing is for certain – modern horror games would not be where they are today if it wasn't for the work of Shinji Mikami. *